the last Russian tsar, Nicholas II, to attend the congress and help usher in the triumph of the new era.[1]

Unbeknownst to most of the delegates attending the congress—close to five thousand in all—the event was accompanied by the largest "fireworks" in world history. On October 30, three days after the Berlin confrontation and one day before the end of the congress, American airplanes collecting air samples around the North Pole detected a major nuclear explosion in the Soviet north. A hydrogen bomb, referred to by the Soviets as either "Big Ivan" or "Tsar Bomba," went off at the Novaia Zemlia Archipelago in the Arctic Ocean. It yielded the explosive power of 58 megatons, compared to the 15 megatons of the Castle Bravo test conducted by the United States at Bikini Atoll in 1954. The largest nuclear explosion in history, it sent an eight-kilometer-wide fireball 60 kilometers into the atmosphere and was visible 1,000 kilometers away. Doctors registered third-degree burns 100 kilometers from the epicenter of the explosion, and houses were completely destroyed at 400 kilometers.[2]

"The test at Novaia Zemlia took place successfully. The safety of those in charge of the test and inhabitants of the region was guaranteed. The proving ground and all those taking part fulfilled the task set by the Motherland," went a telegram sent to Moscow from the test site by two key Soviet officials, Yefim Slavsky, the minister of medium machine-building—the Soviet nuclear superministry—and Marshal Kirill Moskalenko, Khrushchev's key military ally who had helped him arrest Beria in 1953 and was now in charge of the Soviet strategic missile forces. "We are returning to the congress," concluded the telegram. The two Soviet officials, who were delegates to the congress, had skipped the party leaders' speeches to travel to Novaia Zemlia and oversee the test of the new weapon. The explosion of the world's most powerful nuclear device was the Soviet nuclear industry's "gift" to the congress.[3]

On the day the Tsar Bomba was set off, the congress delegates voted to remove the corpse of Joseph Stalin from the mausoleum where it had lain next to Lenin's embalmed remains since Stalin's death in 1953. Khrushchev was now the unquestioned leader of the Soviet Union, having emerged fully from the shadow of his predecessor both at home and abroad. But his rise to the pinnacle of world communism did not go uncontested. The challengers